

From Temple to Court and Beyond

A Cultural and Historical Analysis of Kathak

One of the main forms of Indian classical dance is Kathak. Not only is it a dance performance tradition, but it is also a vibrant cultural art form created throughout centuries of influence in its history, society, and religion. This can be seen in the development of Kathak itself, as it has progressed from temple dance techniques to court dances and today, to dances that appeal to the entire world. As such, it is not proper to define Kathak as merely a traditional dance because its development continues to be influenced by changing contexts. In this vein, the recent studies of Kathak reveal that this dance represents the concept of cultural memory, where history, faith, and emotions can be communicated via movements (Vishwakarma and Vats).

The roots of Kathak are firmly planted in religion and mythology. In line with the spiritual mindset of ancient Indians, it is believed that dance was a divine creation. As stated, “Lord Shiva was so engrossed in the beauty of his consort Parvati that it could find spontaneous expression in dance and thus dance was created” (Banerji 7). From this perspective, it can be seen that dance was not viewed merely as entertainment but as an act of worship involving divine powers and cosmic rhythm in creation and destruction. Traditionally, Kathak originated in temples, where the art of storytelling was significant. In other words, the name Kathak comes from the word *katha*, which means story. In this regard, Kathak dancers were the storytellers whose job entailed the use of bodily movements, music, and gestures to tell stories that revolved around religion. Stories were taken from major epic tales, such as *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata*, making it possible for people to understand philosophical notions. In other words, “dance in early India was offered in the temples for glory of God” (Banerji 7). Furthermore, Kathak had a

wider cultural context besides its religious environment. Besides being places of worship, temples also became artistic places where dancers, musicians, and poets gathered at one place. The inclusion of Devadasis in temples who according to Banerji were ‘maidens dedicated to the service of God’ (Banerji 8) highlights that dance was an inseparable part of religious ceremonies right from its origin.

Additionally, the development of Kathak was also influenced by the Bhakti movement that emphasized devotion and the human-divine relationship. In this atmosphere, dance became an effective means of expressing spiritual emotions. According to Banerji, "Dancing flourished owing to the stimulus given to it by Vaishnavism" (Banerji 13). Devotion is thus a prominent element of Kathak dance. The story of *Krishna Radha* thus assumed greater importance and formed the basis of many aspects of Kathak dance. The performers were able to use these stories as a means of examining issues of love, devotion, and transcendence. According to Vishwakarma and Vats, “Kathak absorbed the devotional elements of the narrative of Krishna”. Consequently, Kathak is yet another example of a dance that evolved as a result of a cultural and religious phenomenon. At the same time, Kathak had some practical purposes during this time. Specifically, the dance served as an educational tool in the Indian culture. The performers would use storytelling to communicate important societal and spiritual messages, teaching people the philosophy and morals of their culture.

One of the defining moments in the history of Kathak happened during the Mughal period. The move of patronage from the temple to the royal courts caused significant changes in the style of the art. As Banerji claims, "Kathak... originated as a new form of dance from Indo-Moghul culture fusion" (Banerji 16). This fusion added Persian aesthetics that include complex patterns, elegant hand movements, and rich costumes. In this context, Kathak changed

from a spiritual practice to an entertaining art. As Banerji mentions, "Thus from a temple art Kathak dance became a court art" (Banerji 22). The purpose of the performance also altered, moving from religious offerings to court entertainment. Moreover, the dancers began to pay special attention to technical skills, rhythmic qualities, and visual attractiveness of the performance. Not only artistic but also social factors played an important role in the process. The absence of temple patronage made many dancers move to the royal courts. In fact, according to Banerji, dancers "became court dancers" due to economic reasons (Banerji 19). Nevertheless, Kathak did not abandon some of its old identity. Instead of rejecting its past, it incorporated new influences and emerged as "a glorious fusion of Hindu and Muslim genius in arts" (Banerji 19). Such an adaptation shows how flexible Kathak is and how well it can connect cultures together.

Colonialism was certainly a difficult period for Kathak. Being governed by Britain at that time, Indian forms of art were often misinterpreted and disrespected. Kathak had been linked with the culture of prostitutes and thus criticized morally. According to Banerji, "Kathak slipped into... houses of ill fame and degenerated steadily" (Banerji 17). This era sheds light on the intricate relationship between art and society. Although dance remained an essential aspect of cultural life, the dancers themselves suffered from social exclusion. Society had "castigated them into the lowest echelon" (Banerji 16-17), thus revealing the hierarchical structure of Indian society. However, it is equally important to note that Kathak survived despite the challenges it faced during this era. The art form remained alive due to devoted artists and the preservation of family traditions. According to Banerji, Kathak survived "separate from 'Nautch Dance'" (Banerji 18).

After India gained independence, Kathak witnessed a revival. The dance form became recognized as a classical art form representing the country's national identity. As stated by

Vishwakarma and Vats, “Kathak had re-emerged as a revitalized classical dance form... as a symbol of national culture.” However, in the present times, Kathak has also evolved as a result of globalization and technology. New digital media and international performance opportunities have enabled Kathak dancers to attract more audiences while at the same time creating problems with the authentic preservation of the tradition. In particular, Vishwakarma and Vats note that "globalization and online pedagogy have increased the reach of Kathak but have presented a challenge regarding authenticity".

Kathak's development has also been influenced by the regional schools of Kathak known as *gharanas*. Three most prominent gharanas of Kathak include Lucknow gharana, Jaipur gharana, and Benaras gharana. As noted by Vishwakarma and Vats, Kathak has "developed centers at Lucknow, Jaipur and Benaras". Each school contributes distinctive stylistic features to Kathak, demonstrating the inner diversity of the dance style. Individuals play an important role in the development and evolution of Kathak dance form as well. For example, Banerji emphasizes the contributions made by the descendants of Kalka-Bindadin to Kathak, including their efforts which helped keep the dance form alive. According to Banerji, Acchan Maharaj, Lachhu Maharaj, and Shambhu Maharaj were among those who contributed to Kathak greatly (Banerji 18). In today's age, dancers like *Birju Maharaj* have been instrumental in promoting Kathak and helping it adjust to the present day scenario. Such people are examples of how individual creativity plays an essential part in the transmission of culture.

The importance of Kathak can be best defined in terms of its use as cultural memory. Unlike in written cultures, Kathak relies on performance as the means for conveying ideas and knowledge that exist in the performance itself rather than in written texts. According to Vishwakarma and Vats, "the dancer's body becomes a 'living archive'"; thus, history is preserved

through dance. This quality of adaptation while still maintaining the same basic principle is what makes Kathak so relevant and interesting over the course of centuries. Adaptability is what provides the basis for the art of Kathak. Every period, be it temple period, court period, colonial period, or the current period brings something new to Kathak without eliminating that which was already acquired before. In this way, there has always been room for social-cultural evolution through the changes in society at large.

It should be noted that each stage through which Kathak evolved, starting from its roots in the temple and ending up with its popularity across the globe, testifies to how complex and flexible the form of this art is. With stages defined by devotion, interaction, social aspects, politics, and the like, Kathak is transformed while preserving its essence. It should be stressed that Kathak as an art is based on the balance between traditional and innovative, spiritual and artistic, and continuity and transformation. To conclude, Kathak is a perfect example of how art reflects the dynamics in the society and serves as a means of cultural preservation simultaneously.

Works Cited

Banerji, Projesh. "Kathak Dance Through the Ages." *Chapters 2–3*.

Vishwakarma, Anukriti, and Parul Purohit Vats. "Kathak and Cultural Memory: Tracing the Dance's Transformations Through Oral and Performative Histories." *ShodhShreejan*, 2025.